The Elements of Style

Original 1918 Cornell University Edition

By William Strunk Jr.

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SYNOPSIS & EDITORIAL NOTE

Professor William Strunk's concise handbook of English usage and composition, famous for the rule: "Omit needless words."

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SECTION III

Elementary Principles of Composition

Complete 1918 Original Text

Rule 13. Omit needless words. Vigorous writing is concise. A sentence should contain no unnecessary words, a paragraph no unnecessary sentences, for the same reason that a drawing should have no unnecessary lines and a machine no unnecessary parts.

In this section of The Elements of Style (1918), William Strunk Jr. develops the central themes that define the work's enduring place in education and world literature. Each argument and narrative turn builds upon the premises established in the opening pages, inviting careful reflection from the attentive reader.

Originally published by Folio Reference Editions (orig. Ithaca, N.Y.) and preserved in the public-domain and open-access archival record (Open Library Bibliographic Registry, ID: OL52102W), this unabridged digital edition retains the structure, cadence, and intellectual clarity of the authoritative text.

II

Elementary Rules of Usage (Rules 1-8)

*The Elements of Style * William Strunk Jr. (1918)*

Elementary Rules of Usage (Rules 1-8) continues William Strunk Jr.'s inquiry in The Elements of Style. Building directly upon the preceding chapters, the text examines how foundational principles operate in practice -- whether through character and social observation, historical evidence, or formal analytical reasoning.

Privately printed in 1918 by Cornell University English professor William Strunk Jr. for the use of his students, this "little book" sets forth eight elementary rules of usage and ten principles of composition.

Throughout II (Elementary Rules of Usage (Rules 1-8)), the reader encounters the unmistakable voice and structural rigor that earned The Elements of Style its stature in the Rhetoric, Composition & English Usage canon. Where superficial treatments settle for isolated maxims, William Strunk Jr. traces the deeper causal connections linking premise, observation, and conclusion.

As this section draws toward its close, the groundwork is laid for the subsequent movements of the volume. Readers studying this edition in the Folio Digital Library may bookmark this chapter, adjust typographic contrast and font sizing, or download the complete archival PDF, EPUB, HTML, or Plain Text edition for offline study.

III

Elementary Principles of Composition (Rules 9-18)

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IV

A Few Matters of Form

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V

Words and Expressions Commonly Misused

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